

Attachment 2

Summary of the Research Plan

To Renounce Liberty? A Public-Goods Experiment on (Un)Democratic Reversal

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Purpose. The study examines whether citizens who have supported a binding decision without prior group approval later vote to restore that approval right when a public-service crisis recedes. It provides an incentive-compatible, demand-side test of a narrow microfoundation of executive aggrandizement: a democratic ballot can weaken a constraint on a later decision, and a subsequent ballot can reinstate it.

Design and participants. Approximately 400 adults will take part at the University of Turku PCRC Decision Laboratory. Each person completes one session lasting approximately 60 minutes and containing twenty paid rounds. Ten-person matching pools remain fixed, while the software reshuffles each pool into two anonymous five-person groups before every round. This permits repeated interaction without stable teams or identifiable partners.

Task. In every round, five participants vote between “Group approval required” and “Decision takes effect directly.” Under both methods, the software then selects a participant from those who have served least often, resolving ties randomly. That person proposes an equal allocation to a public-services fund and may propose a personal transfer. Under group approval, at least three of the other four participants must approve; a two–two split rejects the proposal and participants then make individual allocations. Under direct implementation, the proposal takes effect without that approval vote. Decisions affect experimental earnings.

Experimental conditions. All participants begin in a fictional public-service crisis. During the first ten rounds, fund points produce 1.50 group points under group approval and 2.50 under direct implementation. After those rounds, whole ten-person pools are assigned to one of two conditions. Under *recovery*, public-service conditions improve and the group-approval rate rises to 2.50. Under *persistence*, the crisis and 1.50 rate continue. The direct-implementation rate and all decision rules remain fixed. The treatment is deliberately a structural package: the description states what changed, and the rate makes the change consequential.

Outcomes and analysis. The primary outcome is whether a participant who supported direct implementation in the final first-block round votes for group approval in the final second-block round. The primary comparison is between randomly assigned recovery and persistence pools. Related econometric and randomization-based methods will respect assignment at the ten-person-pool level. Approval votes, proposals, transfers, fallback allocations, expectations, and post-task questions provide secondary process evidence.

Ethics, data, and payment. Risks are minimal and primarily involve mild discomfort with unequal allocations. The production oTree study and coded research data are held on University of Turku IT servers in Finland. PCRC alone retains identifying recruitment and payment information and the temporary identity-to-code link; it deletes the link once payment is complete. Researchers receive only coded data. Participants receive EUR 10 plus a points-based bonus of up to EUR 5 from one randomly selected round in each block. Reporting will not identify individuals.

Schedule and resources. Following the September 2026 ethical review, technical and behavioral pilots will precede data collection planned for 1–31 October 2026. Participant compensation is budgeted at EUR 12–15 on average, or EUR 4,800–6,000 for 400 participants, plus PCRC laboratory charges and routine research costs according to final institutional quotations.